

PA.4 Where to File Directory

How to find out which municipality holds your parcel and how it handles the code, plus the offices beyond the building department that can stop your permit.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Pennsylvania is not a no-code state and it is not a no-inspection state: the Uniform Construction Code applies to every house in the Commonwealth, and five inspections are required on every one of them. What changes from one municipality to the next is *who performs them* — a municipal code official, an agency the municipality retained, or, where the municipality elected not to administer the code at all, an agency **you** hire yourself. Fees, review queues and the local permits stacked on top of the building permit vary too. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it.

FIRST, THE THING THAT CONFUSES EVERYONE

In Pennsylvania the **municipality** — your township, borough or city — is the unit of local government that matters for building. **Counties do not issue building permits.** A county is not a layer above your township for this purpose; it runs a different, much shorter list of things. If you have been calling the county to ask about your building permit, that is why the answers have been unhelpful.

Who does what

Level	What it actually handles
Your municipality (township, borough or city)	The building permit and the UCC — or the notice that it has opted out. Zoning. The sewage permit, through its sewage enforcement officer. Local driveway permits. Any local trade licensing.
Your county	The conservation district for erosion control and stormwater. The recorder of deeds for your deed and any liens. The assessment office. In a few counties, a health department — and in Allegheny County, the plumbing code itself.
The Commonwealth	L&I writes and interprets the UCC, certifies code officials and third-party agencies, and publishes the municipal election table. DEP sets the sewage standards your municipal officer applies. PennDOT permits driveways onto state highways. None of them permits or inspects your house.

THE ONE LOOKUP THAT ANSWERS THE CENTRAL QUESTION

L&I maintains a live table of **every municipality in Pennsylvania**, with its county, its type, whether it elected to administer and enforce the UCC or opted out, the effective date of that election, and the name of its building code official. Look up your own municipality here before you do anything else in this kit.

PA L&I — municipal UCC elections table

pa.gov → Agencies → Labor & Industry → Uniform Construction Code → **Municipal Elections and Contact Information**

When this kit was compiled the table held **2,563 municipalities: 2,444 had opted in and 119 had opted out** — about one in twenty-two. Thirty-four of the sixty-seven counties contain at least one opt-out municipality and no county is entirely opted out, so a neighboring township tells you nothing about yours.

Read the building code official column. On an opt-out row it is blank — because there is no municipal official to name. That blank is the whole finding in PA.1, printed as a gap in a spreadsheet.

Elections change. A municipality may switch on 180 days' notice, and the file is updated continuously — the counts above are September 2026. Check the table rather than trusting this paragraph.

If you are not certain which municipality your parcel is in, the Department of Community and Economic Development runs an address lookup that returns it: **apps.dced.pa.gov → Find Your Municipality**. DCED cautions that the geocoding behind it is outside its control, so on a rural parcel or near a municipal line confirm the answer with the county or the municipality itself. Your deed and your property tax bill also name it. Pennsylvania has many identically named townships in different counties, so always match on **county plus municipality**.

THE OFFICES

Where to file, and where to look things up

Office	What you file or find there	Where
Your municipality	Building permit, zoning approval, sewage permit, local driveway permit. In an opt-out municipality: the written notice that you must obtain your own third-party agency.	Named in the L&I elections table above

Where to file, and where to look things up

Office	What you file or find there	Where
Certified third-party agencies	The list of private agencies certified to perform UCC plan review and inspections. Essential in an opt-out municipality. Agencies marked R can perform the full range of residential approvals — that is the marking you need. Only agencies that volunteered detail are linked to a page showing counties served.	pa.gov → Labor & Industry → Bureau of Occupational and Industrial Safety → Third Party Agencies
Certified code officials search	Individual inspectors and their certification categories. Use it to check independently — L&I's own caveat on the agency list is that entries are “based on information voluntarily provided ... and may not accurately reflect an agency's current complement.”	pa.gov → Labor & Industry → UCC → Certified Code Officials
Sewage enforcement officer (SEO)	Your on-lot sewage permit, soil testing and percolation test. The SEO is retained by your municipality but certified by the Commonwealth — ask the municipal office who theirs is. This is not a UCC function and is not affected by an opt-out election.	Your municipal office. DEP publishes a live active SEOs by county report; standards are at 25 Pa. Code Ch. 73
PA DEP — septic systems	The Commonwealth's homeowner-facing guidance on on-lot systems, and the program under which SEOs are certified. DEP does not normally issue your permit; your municipality does.	pa.gov/agencies/dep → Residents → My Water → Septic Systems ; and Clean Water → Act 537 Sewage Facilities
PA DEP — private wells	Guidance on private water wells, drilling and water testing. Read PA.4's note below on what Pennsylvania does and does not regulate here.	pa.gov/agencies/dep → Residents → My Water → Private Wells
County conservation district	Erosion and sediment control plans and construction stormwater permitting. Every county has one, and it is the office most often missed on a rural lot. Find yours through the state association's directory.	pacd.org

Where to file, and where to look things up

Office	What you file or find there	Where
PennDOT	Highway occupancy permit, if your driveway meets a state highway. Your building permit must carry notice that an HOP is required, and PennDOT has 60 days to act or the permit is deemed issued. Ask for the minimum use driveway form — it covers a driveway expected to carry no more than 25 vehicles a day, which is what a house is.	pa.gov/agencies/penndot ; or your PennDOT district office
PA One Call	Utility line location before you excavate. Confirm whether the homeowner exemption reaches what you are doing — it does not extend to contractors you hire.	pa1call.org
Office of Attorney General — HICPA	Search a home improvement contractor's registration. Remember that new-home construction is outside HICPA, so a sub framing your house may legitimately have no registration (PA.1).	hicsearch.attorneygeneral.gov
County recorder of deeds	Your deed, easements and rights-of-way — which you need for the site plan — and where mechanics' lien claims are filed against your property.	Your county courthouse
FEMA Flood Map Service Center	Confirm whether your lot is in a mapped flood hazard area before you design. Drives the extra submissions in 34 Pa. Code § 403.62a(d).	msc.fema.gov
PA DEP — radon	Pennsylvania has among the highest indoor radon in the country and the UCC requires nothing about it (PA.2). If you want a passive system, this is where the guidance and the certified professional list live.	pa.gov/agencies/dep → Radiation Protection → Radon Division
The law itself	Regulations — anything cited “Pa. Code” — at the first site. Statutes — anything cited “P.S.” — at the second. They are different websites and neither carries the other's material.	pacodeandbulletin.gov legis.state.pa.us

Every address above was checked in September 2026. Pennsylvania moved its agency websites to pa.gov recently and deep links have not been stable through that migration, so this table gives you the agency and the path to click rather than a long URL that may rot — and the two legal-research sites, which have not moved, in full.

TWO PLACES WHERE THIS ALL WORKS DIFFERENTLY

- **Allegheny County.** Plumbing is not a UCC subject here. 35 P.S. § 7210.501(a.1) bars a municipality in a county of the second class from administering and enforcing the plumbing provisions, and the county enforces its own plumbing code under the Local Health Administration Law instead. Expect a separate permit, a separate inspector and county plumber licensing, from the county health department rather than your municipality.
- **Philadelphia.** A city of the first class, with its own department of licenses and inspections, its own permitting system and its own trade licensing. The one place the UCC gives it a different number is the certificate of occupancy clock, which is 10 business days rather than 5 (34 Pa. Code § 403.65(b)) — and the appeal decision deadline, likewise 10 rather than 5.

A NOTE ON WELLS

If your lot needs a well, do not assume the permit-and-inspection pattern you have just learned for sewage carries across to water. It does not. Sewage is governed by a detailed state regulation — 25 Pa. Code Chapter 73 — administered by a certified officer, with isolation distances you can look up. **Ask your municipality whether it has a well ordinance, and ask your driller in writing what construction standard they will build to**, because the answer may be “our own.” Specify casing depth, grouting, the cap and a post-completion water test in the contract rather than assuming an inspector will check them.

The isolation distances in 25 Pa. Code § 73.13 are written from the septic side: the absorption area must be 100 feet from an individual water supply and the treatment tank 50 feet. That is a constraint on where your septic system may go relative to a well — plan both at once, on the same drawing, before either is installed.

THE OFFICES YOU CONFIRMED

Fill this in as you go. On an owner-built house this page is the only place the whole picture exists — and in an opt-out municipality no single office holds it at all.

Confirmed offices for this project

	Item	Date	Confirmed on / notes
☐	Municipality — and its UCC election (opt-in / opt-out) Municipality _____ Election _____		
☐	Building code official, or the third-party agency you engaged Name _____		
☐	Zoning officer Name _____		

Confirmed offices for this project

	Item	Date	Confirmed on / notes
☐	Sewage enforcement officer Name _____		
☐	County conservation district District _____		
☐	PennDOT district — if the driveway meets a state highway District _____ HOP no. _____		
☐	County recorder of deeds — book and page of your deed Book _____ Page _____		
☐	Well driller — and the standard they contracted to build to Driller _____		
☐	Flood zone determination Zone _____ Panel _____		
☐	Local trade licensing required? (electrical / plumbing) Answer _____		

Sources — every Pennsylvania claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Municipalities administer and enforce; five arrangements	35 P.S. § 7210.501(b)
Opt-out: municipality must notify; applicant obtains a certified third-party agency	34 Pa. Code § 403.103(b); 35 P.S. § 7210.501(e)(1)
Municipal election counts, and the officials named	PA L&I municipal elections table, retrieved September 2026
Third-party agencies must be certified by the Department	34 Pa. Code § 401.1; PA L&I third-party agency list
Allegheny County plumbing carve-out	35 P.S. § 7210.501(a.1); 34 Pa. Code § 403.21(a)(6)(i)

Sources — every Pennsylvania claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Certificate of occupancy: 10 business days in cities of the first class	34 Pa. Code § 403.65(b)
On-lot sewage governed by Chapter 73, outside the UCC	34 Pa. Code § 403.21(e)
Septic isolation distances — absorption area and treatment tank	25 Pa. Code § 73.13(b), (c)
Highway occupancy permit notice and PennDOT's 60-day clock	35 P.S. § 7210.502(b)

Every source cited here is free to read, but Pennsylvania keeps statutes and regulations on **two different websites**. A citation reading **Pa. Code** is a regulation — pacodeandbulletin.gov, by title and chapter. A citation reading **P.S.** is a statute, and it is **not on that site at all**; the Pa. Code home page says so outright. Statutes are at legis.state.pa.us → Unconsolidated Statutes, by year and act number — the Construction Code Act is Act 45 of 1999. **One warning:** every Pa. Code chapter prints the Pennsylvania Bulletin issue it is current through, and an amendment published later is already law. Read that line first. All text here was read at those sources, September 2026.